The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Iran struck **Saudi Arabia's** Prince Sultan Air Base, reportedly wounding 12 **American** troops. Earlier Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, vowed to "exact a heavy price" in response to an Israeli attack on two Iranian nuclear facilities. Mr Araghchi claimed the sites produced civilian nuclear energy. He accused Israel of co-ordinating with America, though on Thursday Donald Trump extended his pause on attacks on Iranian energy infrastructure until April 6th.

Steve Witkoff, Mr Trump's envoy to the Middle East, said **America** "was hopeful" of holding meetings with **Iran** "this week". He added that his country "expects an answer" on its 15-point ceasefire proposal. Earlier Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, said his country could achieve its objectives in Iran "without any ground troops" and that its operation would end in "weeks, not months".

American stocks slid for a fifth consecutive week. The S&P 500 closed nearly 1.7% lower, putting it on course for its worst month in almost four years; the NASDAQ fell by more than 2.1%. Meanwhile the price of **Brent crude**, the global oil benchmark, rose to more than $112 a barrel, its highest level since July 2022.

Italy's competition watchdog opened an investigation into **Sephora** and **Benefit** over concerns that the cosmetics companies, which are both owned by LVMH, a French luxury giant, had marketed products to children. Regulators suggested the brands had encouraged "compulsive" purchases, which could fuel "cosmeticorexia", an obsession with skincare and make-up among minors. LVMH denied wrongdoing.

Mr Trump directed the **Department of Homeland Security** to pay airport-security staff, declaring the six-week DHS shutdown an "emergency situation". Meanwhile Republican leaders in the House of Representatives rejected a bill, earlier passed by the Senate, that would have reopened the department, because it failed to fund immigration enforcement. Mike Johnson, the House speaker, will put forward a separate stop-gap funding bill.

Austria became the latest country to propose **social-media** restrictions for young people. The country is drafting legislation to ban under-14s from sites such as TikTok. Similar restrictions will take effect in Indonesia this weekend. Australia was the first country to ban under-16s from social-media platforms in December. At least a dozen countries, including Britain and Spain, are exploring the idea.

Four NASA astronauts began final preparations in Texas ahead of the first crewed journey towards the **Moon** since 1972. The mission (Artemis II), which will launch as early as April 1st, will send them on a ten-day loop around the Moon and back. America is racing China to put the next human on the Moon and ultimately to create a permanent lunar base.

Word of the week: Naxalites, a term for India's Maoist rebels, derived from Naxalbari, a village in West Bengal where their insurrection began in 1967. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

The war’s fifth week brings a fork in the road

Saturday marks a month since America and Israel attacked Iran. The coming week could see ceasefire talks finally start in earnest. Or it could see ground forces enter the conflict for the first time.

On Thursday, Donald Trump extended his pause on attacking Iranian power plants—he says he has given Iran until April 6th to open the Strait of Hormuz. The actual state of negotiations is an enigma. Mr Trump says that talks are proceeding “very well.” Tehran denies they are taking place at all, despite Iranian media reporting that the regime rejected America’s 15-point peace plan and delivered its own counterproposals.

Meanwhile, more American troops have been arriving in the region, including rapid-response paratroopers, special-forces operatives and ships bearing units of marines. They could carry out a range of attacks, including on Iran’s oil terminals and its strongholds along the Strait. No one seems to know if America will escalate or negotiate—including its president.

Photograph: Alamy

No Kings, and no wars

Over 3,000 “No Kings” demonstrations against Donald Trump are expected to take place across America on Saturday. Previous No Kings protests, held last June and October, were among the largest single-day demonstrations in American history. Organisers expect millions to show up waving signs and sporting colourful costumes. Protestors will have much to gripe about, not least Mr Trump’s hugely unpopular war in Iran.

The latest *Economist*/YouGov polling shows that approval for the president’s handling of the war stands at just 36%. Americans are especially worried about rising petrol prices. Though No Kings is mostly backed by left-leaning and progressive types, its organisers are hoping to capitalise on Mr Trump’s unpopularity to broaden their appeal. For Democrats, the protests will be an early indicator of voter mobilisation ahead of the midterms in November. Kings may despise the masses, but, as many find out, the people are hard to ignore.

Photograph: Courtesy of Art Basel

Hong Kong’s complicated art market

With its international connections, trendy galleries and rich residents, Hong Kong has all the trappings of a thriving art market. But the city’s share of global auction sales fell from almost 24% in 2020 to 14.5% last year, according to a report by Mishcon de Reya and ArtTactic. Mainland China’s property crisis and tighter controls on capital outflows have made it harder for buyers to spend big. And a national-security law introduced in Hong Kong in 2020 quashed creative expression, scaring some artists away.

The art world will forget such woes, at least temporarily, when Hong Kong hosts Art Basel this weekend. The biggest and glitziest event in the city’s cultural calendar will host 240 galleries from around the world; last year’s event drew over 86,000 visitors. And on March 25th Hong Kong’s cultural minister announced that the city will hold the event’s Asia installment for another five years. It might not be time to rip up the canvas just yet.

Photograph: Alamy

The rising stars of chess

Magnus Carlsen, a Norwegian grandmaster, once dominated chess. He became a world champion in 2013, defending his title four times before relinquishing it in 2023. Now he has been succeeded by Gukesh Dommaraju (pictured), who in 2024 was crowned the youngest world champion aged 18.

Who challenges Mr Dommaraju for his title next will be determined at the FIDE Candidates tournament, which begins in Cyprus on Saturday. The eight men gathering in the Mediterranean will play a gruelling double round-robin format, where each possible pair faces off twice. Half of the players are newcomers; only one, Fabiano Caruna, an Italian and American grandmaster, has contested a world championship before. And three are under the age of 25. One player to keep an eye on is 20-year-old Javokhir Sindarov from Uzbekistan, whose aggressive tactics have earned him a reputation for upsetting higher-ranked players. The next generation of chess players has arrived.

Photograph: Reuters

Weekend profile: Marco Rubio, the chameleon in Trump's war room

A decade ago Marco Rubio predicted that a government led by Donald Trump would be "chaos". Both men were vying for the Republican presidential nomination. Mr Trump mocked Mr Rubio as "Little Marco".

These days, they are more polite. As Mr Trump's secretary of state, Mr Rubio is studiously deferential to his boss. Calm, articulate and competent, he lends coherence to Mr Trump's foreign policy. He is also the most prominent backer of the hawkish turn it has taken this year. If the current flurry of military adventurism ends well, Mr Rubio will be in a strong position to run again for president.

When Mr Rubio first ran for the Senate in 2010, he started 30 points behind his opponent, a sitting governor, but ended up winning easily. His pitch to voters was partly biographical. His Cuban parents had come to America with no English and no money. They worked hard for their children—his father as a bartender, his mother as a cashier. Mr Rubio, who at 38 was already speaker of the Florida House of Representatives, embodied the immigrant dream. He served for 14 years in the Senate, where he was well respected. In 2025 his peers confirmed him as secretary of state by a 99-0 vote.

To rise and thrive in Trumpworld, Mr Rubio has had to be both ruthless and chameleon-like. As a senator he was a leading advocate of bipartisan immigration reform and of arming Ukraine. Now he serves a master with a penchant for mass deportation and a soft spot for Vladimir Putin. Some doubt Mr Rubio's sincerity. Defenders say he restrains Mr Trump's excesses. European governments see him as one of the few administration officials they can deal with. That Mr Trump has gone quiet about seizing Greenland is, some say, thanks to Mr Rubio.

Mr Rubio's first trip abroad as secretary of state was to Central America and the Caribbean, to help stanch the flow of migrants and set the stage for confrontation with Venezuela. Next in his sights is Cuba; he has said the island needs not just new policies, but new leaders. In the Middle East, the pro-Israel Mr Rubio backed war with Iran. That puts him at the centre of the action—and more exposed if things go wrong.

For his part, Mr Rubio is playing down his ambitions. He says he will support J.D. Vance, the vice president, if he runs in 2028. But Mr Trump is unpopular; voters could pick a Democrat to succeed him. Mr Rubio might think it shrewder to let Mr Vance lose in 2028 and try his own luck in 2032. By that time America's mood may have shifted again. And Mr Rubio will no doubt adapt.

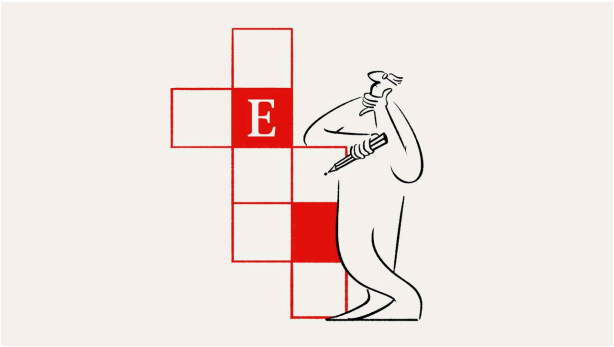

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Praise, in the Common Era, for chatbot (6)

2 across - Posh school got munched, I hear (4)

3 across - In an Asda, queues for tech-heavy stock index (6)

1 down - Drunken gasmen scorn man of the House (11)

Straight clues

1 across - An AI chatbot developed by Anthropic (6)

2 across - Boarding school that has produced 20 British prime ministers (4)

3 across - American tech-heavy stock index (6)

4 across - A male member found inside the Beltway (11)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Rob Blair, Harare Zimbabwe

Wei Shi, Espoo, Finland

Brittany Logan, Washington, DC, America

They all gave the correct answers of: Blue, honey, harvest festival, full house and Red Crescent. The theme is terms associated with the moon: Blue moon, honeymoon, harvest moon, full moon and crescent moon.

The questions were:

Monday: Which 1971 album by Joni Mitchell is often rated as one of the greatest of all time?

Tuesday: Clover, buckwheat and manuka are types of what food product?

Wednesday: What is the term for the annual celebration that occurs in many countries when the crops have been gathered?

Thursday: In poker, what is the term for a hand that contains three of a kind and a pair?

Friday: What is the name of the Islamic equivalent of the Red Cross?

The only thing that saves us from the bureaucracy is inefficiency. An efficient bureaucracy is the greatest threat to liberty.

Eugene McCarthy